FRANCIS WILLIAMS

A PRIME MINISTER REMEMBERS

THE WAR AND POST-WAR MEMOIRS
OF
THE RT HON. EARL ATTLEE
K.G., P.C., O.M., C.H.

Based on his Private Papers and on a Series of Recorded Conversations



HEINEMANN

LONDON MELBOURNE TORONTO

Author's Note

This book bears the same title as a filmed conversation piece between Lord Attlee and myself which was broadcast on B.B.C. television on 3 January 1959, on the occasion of his seventy-sixth birthday. The success of this programme, which won wide appreciation and was quoted and commented on all over the world, led to my suggesting to Lord Attlee that similar conversations reviewing his long period of office as Deputy Prime Minister and Prime Minister throughout twelve of the most momentous years in British history might be of great interest if incorporated in a book of memoirs drawing upon many of his private papers covering these years.

He agreed. My writing of this volume was preceded by many hours of conversation between Lord Attlee and myself spread over many days. Verbatim extracts from the tape recordings of these conversations have been used where they throw new light on the events in which Lord Attlee played so major a part and on the personalities involved in them. Lord Attlee also placed at my disposal all his records and private papers. These we went through together and discussed before I started writing and he subsequently made a number of emendations and additions to the draft of the manuscript which I sent him.

This book is, therefore, in part a history, approved by Lord Attlee, of these critical years based on contemporary sources, on hitherto unpublished private papers and on Lord Attlee's own records and recollections, and in part a retrospective comment on events and people by Lord Attlee as he looks back on judg-

ments, achievements – and mistakes. I hope that this combination of narrative and conversation may be found by many to bring fresh insights, not only into recent history, but also into the character of Lord Attlee himself.

Most of the conversations recorded took place at Lord Attlee's home, Cherry Cottage, Prestwood, Great Missenden, Buckinghamshire, and I am deeply grateful to Lady Attlee for the charm and goodwill with which she bore my many intrusions and for her hospitality on so many occasions. Thanks are also due to Sir Norman Brooke for the assistance he gave Lord Attlee in tracing a number of telegrams to President Truman and others of which Lord Attlee himself had not kept copies; and to Mr Arthur Moyle, M.P., Lord Attlee's P.P.S. during the great part of his period at 10 Downing Street, for his helpful guidance in those passages concerned with the internal affairs of the Labour Party.

I must also thank Mr Jack Hill for his invaluable assistance with the tape recording, my secretary, Mrs R. Wyer, for the skill and patience with which she dealt with a difficult manuscript, and my wife, as always, for her unfailing advice and help.

II

Holding the Line against Russia

In the main Attlee left foreign affairs to Ernest Bevin, intervening only in moments of particular crisis or when Bevin asked him to. He believed that 'foreign affairs are the province of the Foreign Secretary. It is in my view a mistake for a Prime Minister to intervene personally except in exceptional circumstances.' He took the view that the constant participation by Heads of State in matters which depend upon skilled and patient negotiation and in which there are few short cuts to success was often more likely to promote than avoid crisis and that one should appoint a strong Foreign Secretary and leave the handling of affairs to him. The fashion of Summit Conferences in peace-time with all their attendant publicity seemed to him to have, more often than not, more risk than advantage – 'There's a lot in the proverb: "If you've got a good dog you don't bark yourself." '

The two men were very close; closer than any others in the Cabinet. They understood each other and trusted each other wholly, there were never any reservations between them, and Bevin, who preferred speech to memoranda, made a habit of privately talking over problems which troubled him with Attlee, not so much on a Foreign Secretary-Prime Minister basis as for the purpose of thinking aloud and drawing upon Attlee's sharp, detached judgment as a corrective to his own exuberant vision; their minds were in many ways complementary. No record was kept of these conversations and they did not, of course, in any way replace Cabinet discussions on foreign policy. But they played an important part in formulating both men's views, as did also the personal letters which Bevin often wrote to Attlee from abroad.

Attlee has described his feeling for Bevin in this judgment:

'My relationship with Ernest Bevin was the deepest of my political life. I was very fond of him and I understand that he was very fond of me . . .

'Like Stafford Cripps he was a tremendous egotist – Ernest having the egotism of the artist, Stafford the egotism of the altruist, and Stafford thought well enough of Ernest to suggest to him that he would make a better Prime Minister than I would in 1947. Ernest did not reciprocate this compliment.

'We understood each other very well. I was not a working man but I had lived and worked among the workers in Limehouse. It was my view that the purpose of a Labour Prime Minister was to work for the common man – not the little man but the man that is in all of us – irrespective of class and income. Ernest came to see that because a man had been to a public school it did not mean that he was on the other side of the hill. As the years went by he saw more and more of the foolishness that trade unionists can sometimes display and more of the loyalty of Labour supporters among the professional middle classes. He certainly knew that I would give up being leader at any time this seemed in the interest of the party and I think this appealed to him. I also think he liked the fact that I didn't talk too much. . . .

'Because of his own genius for organisation and his confidence in his own strength, he did not fear – he embraced – power. Lord Acton's famous dictum on power probably never occurred to him. And if he agreed that power corrupts he would have said that it corrupted only the men who were not big enough to use it. Power was given to him. He attracted it as a natural leader. It did not corrupt him . . .'

There was at all times close understanding between them. Bevin always kept Attlee fully informed as to what was in his mind and regularly sought his judgment, so that foreign policy was in a very real sense a joint affair, and there were never any serious differences between them. Attlee therefore kept clear of

most of the regular business of diplomacy and international negotiation, knowing that Bevin would always turn to him if the need for his intervention arose.

One such occasion came early during the first Foreign Ministers' Conference in London when, adopting a method that was to become only too well-known later on, Russia suddenly faced the Conference with a procedural crisis.

When Bevin informed him of what had happened, Attlee at once telegraphed to Stalin, sending a copy to President Truman on the same day.

'Prime Minister to Marshal Stalin. 23.9.45

'A difference of opinion arose yesterday over the composition of the Council of Foreign Ministers for the purpose of its work on the preparation of peace treaties. Discussion centred round the interpretation of the Berlin Protocol.

'Mr Bevin maintained that the overriding provision was the decision to establish the Council composed of the Foreign Ministers of the U.K., U.S.S.R., China, France and the U.S.A. to do the necessary preparatory work for the peace settlements (paras A and A (i) of Part 1 of the Protocol of the Berlin Conference), and that the Council as a whole is thus responsible for discharging all the tasks remitted to it. He therefore maintained that the following decision reached by the Council on September 11 is correct:—

> "It was agreed that all five members of the Council should have the right to attend all meetings and take part in all discussions, but that in matters concerning peace settlements members whose Governments had not been signatories to the relevant terms of surrender should not be entitled to vote."

'I also share this view. I have spoken to Mr Eden, who tells me that his understanding at the Potsdam Conference was that the Council was free to arrange its own procedure and that it was not

bound within the limits of the exact terms of the Potsdam Agreement.

'M. Molotov considers that the decision of the Council on September 11 was a violation of the Potsdam Agreement, that it should be rescinded and that in future the Council, for the work on the peace treaties, should be composed only of the Foreign Ministers of the States signatory to the Armistices and that, whilst the U.S.A. would be added in the case of Finland, China would be excluded altogether and France from all the treaties except the Italian. This does not accord with my understanding of the spirit and intention of the decision arrived at in Potsdam.

'The decision of the Council on September 11 was agreed to by the five Ministers present, including M. Molotov, and it accords with the understanding held in good faith by the U.S. and British Foreign Secretaries. It seems to be beyond question that the Council was entitled to adopt the above resolution (see paragraph A(4) (ii) Part 1 of the Berlin Protocol). Moreover, it cannot be held to depart in any way from the Potsdam decision, as the restriction of vote means in effect that the Council will be composed for taking decisions as proposed. Since this question has been referred to me I should like to touch on a broader aspect of the matter. The decision of September 11 was adopted unanimously after discussion and I should view with grave misgiving the institution of a precedent for calling in question decisions so taken and seeking to reverse them and therefore rejecting the conclusion arrived at by the British Foreign Minister acting in faithful concert with the other Foreign Ministers. That, I should fear, would change altogether in an adverse sense the nature and indeed the value of the Council of Foreign Ministers and introduce an element of confusion into their proceedings. Indeed I doubt whether it would be possible to gain unanimous consent of the Council to a reversal of its earlier decision and any attempt to do so would clearly cause grave offence to France and China and be completely misunderstood here by the public and Parliament, to whom we reported in good faith that the Council would act as a Council of

Five, a statement which was received with a sense of relief in this country. M. Molotov argues that under his proposals the work of the Council would be greatly accelerated. Even if this were so, which is by no means proved by the course of the discussions, it would certainly not counterbalance the damage to harmonious collaboration caused by the offence given. To my mind the success of the present conference and indeed the whole future of the Council and confidence in a just peace is at stake. Therefore I earnestly hope that you will agree to authorise your delegation to adhere to the decision taken on September 11. After all it is peace we are endeavouring to establish, which is more important than procedure.'

This telegram had some result. When, having reached deadlock in London, the Foreign Ministers met for a second time in Paris, Molotov, acting as always on the instructions of his master – for it soon became clear to all the others that he was allowed no power of independent judgment – abandoned his demands without further argument or explanation.

But the final sentence of Attlee's letter awakened no response in Stalin's mind.

Instead it became clear as the months passed and the Foreign Ministers moved from capital city to capital city that Russia and the Western Powers were fundamentally opposed in their attitudes towards a German peace treaty. Nor was Stalin interested in lessening tension and bridging the differences between East and West. The Soviet tactics were directed to securing piecemeal agreements on reparations and kindred matters in which they were particularly interested while blocking any wider approach. Bevin with Attlee's backing sought an overall agreement and refused to compromise on detail, convinced that whatever was done must be done as part of a total pattern. Nor was he ready to secure a peace treaty at the cost of allowing Russia to take from Germany immense reparations which would in practice have to be met by the Western occupying Powers.

'I am not prepared,' he told Molotov, 'to face Parliament after

leaving this room with the implication that I have bought the peace conference from the Soviet Union for one hundred million dollars.'

His growing irritation with tactics which were to continue throughout his period of office – and that still continue to bedevil hope of agreement – was later expressed in a long personal letter, sketching in sharp and pessimistic phrases the atmosphere of these seemingly endless talks, which he wrote to Attlee from Moscow when the Foreign Ministers met there in the course of their interminable perambulations:

United Kingdom Delegation to the Council of Foreign Ministers, Moscow. 16th April, 1947

'Dear Clem,

'I have been waiting to give you a reply on the question you raised as to the atmosphere of the Conference, but it was very difficult to determine at that moment whether there would be a good outcome or not. And I agree with you that it is very difficult to get the sense of things from the telegrams.

'The time has now come, however, to give you a picture of the whole situation here as I see it. At the opening of the Conference, as you realise, Marshall, from the United States, was new to it and largely in the hands of his delegation, and he seemed to be groping his way to get a grip of the essential problems. I therefore had to take the lead for several weeks and decided, in order to try and focus attention on the issue as a whole which would have to come before the Conference, that after a reasonable exchange of views I would table what we have called our New Potsdam, which is a constructive piece of work and which is in line with the Cabinet decisions. The method I adopted was at each discussion to make my statement and then table a section and finally put in a paper as a whole.

'But the real issue of the Conference has not been faced and I am afraid we are going to break down because the Russians will not face it, and that is the fundamental question of economic unity in Germany and the type of political principles that must

be adopted if we are to get a democratic Germany, that is, democracy as we understand it, and the carrying out of the organisation of Germany to the next stage towards the final evolution of a German state and government. The Russians clearly in this field want to create a situation in which everyone will forget what they have done in their Zone and we shall be forced to ignore the hundreds of millions we have had to put into our Zone, and the Americans into their Zone, and that they shall be able to come in, disregarding all this, force the British and American taxpayer to stand it, rehabilitate their own Zone at our expense and then on top of that get reparations from current production.

'The discussions on these items have been very cold, frank but firm. The result is that it is impossible to reconcile the instructions given to me by the Cabinet with the desires and determination of Russia to loot Germany at our expense. It is true that they have accepted some of the principles, but certain other vital ones they will not accept.

'The strategy I employed was to avoid the mistake made at Yalta and Potsdam of dealing with things separately and getting committed on one point, only to find that the Russians would not budge on the next item. Therefore I stipulated that I would not be committed until I had seen the problem as a whole and could ascertain whether any decision would involve additional cost for Great Britain, whether it would provide repayment for what we had put into Germany, and whether over reparations we should be treated quite fairly.

'Another very serious situation has developed and that is this. At Yalta the Russians talked about 20 billion dollars' reparations for the Allies. At Potsdam I understood, and I thought you did, that the decisions taken there settled reparations from the Western Zones; also there was the fact that, with the territory that had been taken away from Germany and other obligations imposed upon her, there was a tremendous population in a circumscribed area. Taking this and the cutting down of her industrial potential under the Potsdam Agreement into account,

I cannot see how current reparations can be paid unless they are provided from America and Great Britain.

'We have had this tussle over again on the question of Ruhr coal. The Russians refuse to put their coal into the pool and we cease to allocate through the Control Council. The Russians and the French have therefore been pressing that we should have a special régime for the Ruhr. I have stuck to Cabinet policy that I would not have any four-Power control of the Ruhr unless it applied to Germany as a whole. It is quite clear what the Russians are after, namely, to get into the Ruhr, to make our Zone impossible to work and to create a disturbance so as to get a grip on that great area. In this the United States stood with me, but France first of all stood for the detachment of the Ruhr altogether from Germany. She has withdrawn from that position and is now pressing for a four-Power régime, whereas no one more than France prevented the Central Agencies, agreed at Potsdam, from being put into operation. Again therefore I have had to say that when I get Potsdam as a whole I will honour it as a whole, but it is not permissible to pick out little bits which suit this or that country and ignore the obligations and then try to impose it upon the British. In all this I have had a very difficult task, but I regard it as imperative that it should be maintained.

'On the political principles the Russians and ourselves came very near together. The Americans and the French wanted the Central Government appointed from the Laender, that is to say, you would elect people to the local government and from that local government you would select so many people to form the national government. Whereas in the principles that I submitted, I put forward that all powers should be retained in the Laender that were not specifically reserved to the Central Government, but that the Central Government should be elected by Germany as a whole. Since the discussion I have had another talk with the Americans and I find there has been some misunderstanding. They do not appear to object to the Government being elected as a whole but what they are anxious about is that the control of the electoral machinery should be in the hands

of the Laender. On that I am prepared to meet them. I think that is right and never intended anything else. It would be the same as our own constituencies controlling the elections in the localities. The other great difficulty is that the Russians want proportional representation, which applies practically throughout the Continent. I have reserved my position on this until we have had a chance to consult the Germans. In the end I am afraid I should be compelled to give way to proportional representation because of its universality, but I have put it straight to the Russians that I could be no party to enabling them to get a one-party Government in Germany.

'The other great issue we have had to face is the question of the Austrian Treaty. Discussion in detail will be reached to-day. But the trouble there in the main is the question of German assets in Austria. We have made two attempts to resolve this and have referred it back to the Deputies, but the disagreement seems worse than ever now and I do not know what the outcome of this discussion will be today. On the one hand I am told that it is better for Austria to have the Treaty even if we have to yield on this question of German assets, while on the other I get messages conveyed to me from other parties in Austria that it would be fatal if I did it. It is a difficult thing to decide. It all comes out of Potsdam because we failed to give a definition of German assets and we have taken the line that the Soviets ought not to profit by the rascality of Hitler. We have made proposals as to debts and also as to machinery for determining the definition of the German assets so as to exclude those taken by Hitler under force and duress during the period of the Anschluss.

'You will have seen from the papers to-day that the talks on the Four-Power Treaty have virtually broken down. It would have been farcical were it not so tragic. I admit that the Americans put this forward in Paris without very much thought, but it did offer to France, Great Britain and Russia a chance to build a bridge on the one issue of demilitarisation and the prevention of aggression. I felt that, if it had been received in the manner it ought to have been by Russia, the bridge between East and West

would really have been built and the antagonism which is growing so fast in the United States would have been checked. Instead of that the Russians wanted to put in economics, demilitarisation, limitation of industrial potential, agrarian reform, which we have already agreed should be part of the German Treaty, and a whole host of things which made it quite clear that they did not want the Four-Power Treaty at all. Marshall reacted very coolly but very strongly. In fact, it was the first time in the Conference in which he was quite clearly speaking as the Secretary of State and not as the spokesman of the delegation. Bound up with this discussion yesterday was the future fate of Europe and of the world and it was very sickening and saddening to see such a great opportunity thrown away. The best description I can give of Molotov's statement was that it was a product of an irascible mind and very, very much like the old discussion that used to go on in the old International pre-1914, where they argued for days about words and theories of the most unpractical kind. I took the line, when the proposal was made, that this thing should go to a special committee with all these additions of the Russians; that we had been here five weeks; that we had been discussing every item proposed but had failed to settle even the short-term aspect, and that if he now passed it on to a committee with no decision it was really playing with the whole situation. For myself I think Russia has made a great mistake – as bad as she made just before the outbreak of war when she lined up with Hitler.

'For us as Britishers in between the two of them, our task is very difficult. I have caused the discussion to be started in connexion with our treaty and the Russians have put up counter-proposals, but I feel we dare not go an inch beyond the French Treaty. We run too great a risk if we do. I am waiting for the replies from the Chiefs of Staff on the points which we sent, and after that I will write to the Soviet Government, but I feel that whatever happens we must content ourselves with a treaty on those lines.

'I have tried to keep in touch with the other three delegations here as far as one humanly can.

'Finally, returning to the atmosphere here, it looks to me as if we are getting perilously near a position in which a line-up is taking place. I had hoped that when I came to Moscow it could all have been avoided, and I think a little more salutary attitude on the part of the Russians and better methods of handling their problems would have succeeded. I do not of course know what happened last night. Marshall saw Stalin and whether the outcome of that talk will make it better or worse I have not yet heard a word and cannot judge. We shall see to-day.

'There is courtesy, there are no high words being used, no tempers, but all of it is cool, calculated and between the two big boys looks to me to be pretty determined.

'I trust you are well and will get through the Budget difficulties all right. I can assure you that I shall be glad to leave Moscow. I am fed up with this long stay here. There are such little or no results.

Yours sincerely,
ERNEST BEVIN'

In their approach to foreign policy, circumstances, it seemed to both Attlee and Bevin, compelled them to give most weight to three main considerations.

There was in the first place the need, if it could by any means be managed, to make the United Nations a powerful and effective international instrument. This was not only because that it should become so was to both of them a matter of moral principle – especially so in an atomic age when a new pattern of international relations seemed to offer the only real hope of the survival of civilisation – but also because they saw in it the best means by which responsibilities that Britain's resources no longer enabled her to carry could be transferred in such a way as to help unify and not divide the world.

British interests were historically opposed to the domination of Europe by one Great Power. They required that the complex of world communications linking the Commonwealth should be kept open and secure and that political and economic means

should be found to make possible the rapid, peaceable development of new nations in Asia and Africa, as old colonial relationships inevitably came to an end. And they called for peaceful and stable advance in the Middle East, which might otherwise become a new cockpit of power politics.

If the United Nations could be made into a reality all these issues would take on a different and more amenable form. Problems of security directly affecting British and Commonwealth interests would become more soluble. The risk of a dangerous power vacuum developing if Britain was compelled by economic and other circumstances to reduce her commitments would appreciably diminish.

For all these reasons both were anxious to avoid the kind of power line-up to which Bevin referred in his long private letter to Attlee, since any such line-up, by placing the United States and Soviet Russia – 'the big boys' – firmly on opposite sides, would make co-operation within the United Nations more difficult, if not impossible.

But the development of international confidence to such a level as to make the United Nations a fully effective and practical instrument was, even on the most optimistic view, bound to take considerable time. While it developed it was essential to avoid reducing British commitments in such a way as to create power vacuums out of which might come new conflicts. To leave nothingness behind might tempt the Soviet to strike out for domination over the whole of Europe and the Middle East and thus divide the world beyond hope of repair.

Attlee and Bevin were thus compelled throughout the whole of the post-war period to play for time. They had to fight a holding operation. It was one which Britain's limited resources and pressing economic and defence problems made it virtually impossible for her to win without American help, only obtainable if the United States could be brought to realise that her own interests, no less than those of Britain and Europe, required her to oppose the expansion of Soviet power in Europe and the Middle East.

From Potsdam onwards it was plain that Stalin was determined, if he could, to block any peace treaty that would facilitate the emergence of democratically elected Governments in liberated Europe and thus reduce the likelihood of Communist domination. It was plain also that Britain's material weakness was a potent factor in Soviet calculations. Russia herself was, at this time, in no position to risk a major conflict. But if Britain could be forced to contract her dangerously extended commitments before America was ready to take over, she might be able to move in without one.

To an extent that is often forgotten in the light of later events Britain therefore became during this period the primary, and, indeed, for long periods at a time almost the sole, target of Soviet diplomatic and propaganda attacks in Turkey, the Dardanelles, Persia, Greece, the Middle East and elsewhere.

While trying to prevent so absolute and frozen an alignment of Big Power groupings as to destroy any real hope of the ultimate development of an effective United Nations organisation, Attlee and Bevin were for this reason compelled to face up to the reality of Soviet ambitions much earlier than the preoccupations of American domestic politics allowed the United States administration to do so. American public opinion was slow to move from the belief that a satisfactory division of interests between Russia and America was possible, or to shake itself free of a traditional suspicion of what were regarded as British imperialist motives. To this was added in some important official quarters a considerable contempt for British weakness.

Admiral Leahy, President Truman's Chief of Staff, was known to have canvassed at Potsdam the opinion[1] that Britain was 'prostrate economically' and 'relatively impotent militarily' and that the Soviet Union must be accepted as 'the unquestioned, all-powerful influence in Europe.' And Harry Hopkins, whom Truman had sent on a mission to Moscow immediately after the end of the war in Europe, had reported back that in his opinion no

1. Subsequently repeated in his memoirs, *I Was There*, published in 1950, based on his diaries and notes.

major source of conflict between Russia and American interests existed in any part of the world. It was, therefore, he advised, of vital importance that the United States should not be manœuvred into a position where they were lined up in a bloc against Russia to implement Britain's European policy.

These may seem strange views in the light of future American policy, but they were important at the time. Although not shared in the same measure by Truman himself, they coloured American thinking. Above all at this stage American public opinion was unwilling to support any policy that seemed to be pulling British chestnuts out of the fire or entangling the United States in a British alliance. Attlee and Bevin had to play for time – although time was running out – and be very careful not to frighten America into a new isolationism by precipitate action.

It was in this delicate situation that Winston Churchill delivered his famous Fulton speech. The immediate reaction of the Foreign Office was one of consternation, not so much because of the content of the speech as because of its possible effect in America. This anxiety was increased when the first telegrams from Washington reported that the speech had been widely misinterpreted as an expression of British official opinion and that the reference to 'fraternal association' contained in it had been seized on by a good deal of public opinion as the beginning of an attempt to manœuvre America into an unwanted alliance. This was the more troublesome in that it came at the very moment when the American loan to Britain was before Congress.

However, while Attlee and Bevin were considering the implications of these reports a personal telegram from Churchill arrived containing important news.

Dated 7 March 1946 and marked 'Personal from Churchill for the Prime Minister and Foreign Secretary', it reported that although Churchill had not, of course, consulted any members of the American Government on the exact text of his speech, President Truman had read a mimeographed copy of the final draft on the train to Fulton some hours before it was delivered: 'He told me that he thought it was admirable and would do

nothing but good though it would make a stir.' The President, Mr Churchill's telegram continued, had 'seemed equally pleased before and after.' A copy of the speech had also been shown in advance to Mr Byrnes, the Secretary of State, who was excited by it and suggested no alterations, and to Admiral Leahy, who was enthusiastic. Mr Churchill added that, although, of course, he took personal responsibility for what he had said, and had altered nothing as a result of his contacts with these high American authorities, he thought Attlee and Bevin ought to know their reaction.

His telegram also contained advance news of a significant development in American policy towards the Near East which was to prove of considerable importance in paving the way for the 'Truman Doctrine' of a year later that security in the eastern Mediterranean was an American interest.

The Turkish Ambassador had died in Washington and Churchill telegraphed that on the train to Fulton President Truman had told him that he had decided to send the body back to Turkey in the American battleship *Missouri*. This was the ship on which the Japanese surrender had been signed and was probably the strongest battleship afloat. The *Missouri* would be accompanied by a strong task force which would remain in the Sea of Marmora for an unspecified period. Mr Churchill commented: 'This strikes me as a very important act of State and one calculated to make Russia understand that she must come to reasonable terms of discussion with the Western democracies.' He added that from the British point of view he felt sure that the arrival and stay of such a powerful American fleet in the Straits must be entirely beneficial. It would reassure Turkey and Greece and it would place 'a demurrer on what Bevin called cutting our line through the Mediterranean by the establishment of a Russian naval base at Tripoli.'

Finally Mr Churchill wrote that after spending nearly three days in intimate friendly contact with President Truman and his immediate circle and after having a long talk with Mr Byrnes he had no doubt that the American leaders were deeply distressed

at the way they were being treated by Russia and did not intend to put up with treaty breaches in Persia or encroachments in Manchuria and Korea or pressure for Russian expansion at the expense of Turkey or Greece in the Mediterranean. 'I am convinced,' he concluded, 'that some show of strength and resistance is necessary to a good settlement with Russia. I predict that this will be the prevailing opinion in the United States in the near future.' This was good news indeed.

Churchill's attitude on the American loan while he was in the States was also encouraging.

A personal telegram from Sir Ben Smith, the Minister of Food, who was in Washington, reported:

'Minister of Food to Prime Minister. 12th March, 1946

'Yesterday I attended a lunch which the National Press Club gave to to Winston Churchill. He answered questions for the best part of an hour. He was cross-examined particularly on the British loan.

'After admitting that there were a number of points about it which he did not like, he developed a strong case in support of the loan's passage by Congress and said it would be "a disaster" if it were turned down. He also vigorously repudiated the suggestion that the loan would merely be a subsidy to Socialism and stressed the fundamental solidarity of the British people. He added that if the loan were not granted we should still get through somehow because the British people would never be beaten.

'Altogether he gave us helpful support and his statements should go a good way to offset the effect here of the attitude of the Opposition to the loan agreement.'

Attlee telegraphed his thanks to Churchill:

'Prime Minister to Mr Churchill. 13 March, 1946

'I have just heard from Ben Smith of the very helpful remarks which you made at the National Press Club luncheon about the

American loan, and I should like to send you my warm thanks and appreciation for the friendly line you took.

'Thank you also for the long and interesting telegram which you sent Bevin and me on March 7 – I hope we may have a talk on your return. I have shown the telegram to Eden.

'I trust that the remainder of your stay will be pleasant, and that you are keeping well. Best wishes to Mrs Churchill and yourself.'

However, although Truman's decision to send a task force to the eastern Mediterranean represented an important step in American involvement in European affairs – and a plain warning to the Soviet that the United States would not stand aside if Russia translated aggressive diplomacy into aggressive action – it did little at this stage to reduce the financial and defence burdens which Britain was finding it increasingly difficult to carry in view of her own grave economic problems. At the Treasury Hugh Dalton continually pressed for a reduction of financial commitments overseas. They were not easy to achieve.

From Paris, on 13 August 1946, Bevin wrote to Attlee in the course of a letter on proposed Cabinet changes, 'I am not making the headway I would like in making it possible to reduce our commitments so as to help Hugh; the Russians are very difficult.'

On the same day two other letters arrived on Attlee's desk from Bevin. One expressed Bevin's anxiety lest too much was being given away about British methods in the Defence White Paper on the setting up of a Ministry of Defence:

Paris

'Dear Clem, 13 August 1946

'I was very concerned when I read your scheme for Minister of Defence and Defence Organization was to be published as a White Paper. Why must we reveal this to the world? It is the result of years of experience and effort. We have not promised. Cannot we get the Bill through without revealing every detail as

this does? The intelligence, planning and execution is opposite to the German and, I think, the Russian systems. If the Germans had used this system they might have won. Why must we weaken ourselves? See paragraph 30. It may justify our Chiefs of Staff system, but I cannot see that the paper has much to do with a Minister of Defence except as a piece of internal organization.

'Please look into it again. Yours sincerely,

ERNEST BEVIN'

The other, on reorganisation at the Foreign Office as part of a Ministerial reshuffle regarding which Attlee had written to him, revealed his growing sense of the strain of continual conferences:

Paris

'Dear Clem, 13th August 1946

'I am answering your note under separate headings,

'1. *Foreign Office.*

I have long been considering the reorganization of the Foreign Office. I agree with you about N.B.[1] I think he will do well and his knowledge of my Policy will be useful in shaping defence, and he did well at War Transport. This will relieve me of having anyone on a functional basis.

'I have refrained from asking you to appoint another Parliamentary Secretary because of the difficulty of fitting one in, but it is no use disguising the fact that I cannot stand the strain of the last six years. Further, I am satisfied that I must make arrangements for the posts abroad to be visited, reorganized and brought up-to-date, and I must be able to have more contacts with other States. At the same time, if we are to do the job properly these young men must be trained. Therefore what I would like, if you can give it to me, is as follows:—

'Hector McNeil as Minister of State, and he would be my chief substitute in my absence for Defence Committee, conference

1. Mr Philip Noel-Baker, Minister of State, who was promoted to be Secretary of State for Air. Subsequently Secretary of State for Commonwealth Relations.

work, helping me with peace conferences, i.e., Germany and Japan (I am writing you separately on Control of Germany) and certain branches of U.N.O.

'I would like Mayhew, the present Parliamentary Private Secretary to Morrison, as a Parliamentary Secretary. I like him; he has a good economic sense and would be able to help me in the economic field and handle the House well. I have had my eye on him. It would also help the Party in East Anglia.

'Then Gordon Walker as the second Parliamentary Secretary. He is good and reliable and would help me with the British Council, Public Relations and the B.B.C., and he is a good negotiator.

'I should then have a good set-up.

'I hope you can see your way to do this.

Yours sincerely,

ERNEST BEVIN'

But although Bevin sometimes felt that the pressure of work was growing almost unbearable, this did not prevent him from adding to his responsibilities.

Next day yet another letter for Attlee arrived, this time proposing that the Foreign Office should be given a much larger control of German and Austrian affairs:

United Kingdom Delegation
Paris

'Dear Clem, 14th August 1946

'The question of the Control Office for Germany and Austria has been giving me great concern. I have to face all the political implications, at home, at meetings of the Council of Foreign Ministers, and in our relations with France.

'I had thought of putting up to you the proposal contained in the draft minute which I attach. The effect of it is to give me and the Foreign Office a more effective part in the political side and to confine the Control Office to the purely administrative problems.

'I am in a real difficulty about this because while on the one hand I do not want Hynd to be displaced or reduced, as I think he is capable and promising, I am advised that in practice division between political and administrative questions may not be possible. Sargent had a private talk with Jenkins, the Permanent Secretary at the Control Office, and Jenkins's view was that the only satisfactory arrangement would be the drastic course of reducing the Control Office to a department of the Foreign Office reporting direct to me.

'Would you have a look at my draft paper and let me know what you think? Perhaps we could discuss it when I return.

Yours sincerely,
ERNEST BEVIN'

Detailed suggestions for bringing directly under Bevin himself all major German and Austrian issues, including directions to the Commander-in-Chief in Germany on all political matters, followed.

Such preoccupations at no time prevented Bevin from taking an interest in many other things nor from corresponding regularly with Attlee when he was away on any matter on which he thought his friend the Prime Minister might like to have his views. Thus from Paris the same day that he sent his memorandum on Germany he also wrote Attlee a note urging him to 'keep a pretty close control of it [defence] yourself' when a Defence Minister was appointed. Another suggested that 'Shawcross needs to be spoken to. His actions and speeches in Poland outside of his sphere were not too helpful.' A third came down strongly against a suggestion that a former Labour Member who had refrained from fighting at the 1945 Election should be given a seat in the Lords: 'A man who plays for safety as he has done and then to be taken into office or put up to represent the Party in the Lords is a bad decision and will cause misgiving. Is there no defeated candidate who made at least a good fight?'

The complications of a diplomacy in which Britain had little

power of manoeuvre and in which Attlee and Bevin were forced increasingly to recognise the real nature of Stalin's aggressive ambitions, not only by Russia's public acts but by Molotov's attitude in the face of every effort to reach agreement at the Foreign Ministers' Conference, were sometimes made worse by the public utterances of prominent members of the Labour Party whose opinions were given more weight abroad than they really had. Almost inevitably Harold Laski often appeared in this role, much to Attlee's and Bevin's irritation. One such utterance by Laski quite early on brought the following letter from Attlee:

'My dear Harold, 20 August 1945

'Your letter has just reached me and I hope you will make useful contacts in the Scandinavian countries. I thank you also for your kindly reference in your *Reynolds*' article. I am however bound to point out to you that the constant flow of speeches from and interviews with you are embarrassing.

'As Chairman of the Labour Party Executive, you hold an important office in the Party and the position is not well understood abroad. Your utterances are taken to express the views of the Government.

'You have no right whatever to speak on behalf of the Government. Foreign Affairs are in the capable hands of Ernest Bevin. His task is quite sufficiently difficult without the embarrassment of irresponsible statements of the kind which you are making.

'I had hoped to have seen you but you were away in Paris. I can assure you there is widespread resentment in the Party at your activities and a period of silence on your part would be welcome.

Yours ever,
CLEM'

Divisions within the Parliamentary Labour Party on major issues of policy were of more consequence. To Bevin, schooled in the trade union tradition of loyalty, some of the attacks launched against him by the 'left wing' at a time when he was in the middle

of negotiations in which any suggestion of British weakness or disunity could in his view prove fatal were quite intolerable. He could not accustom himself to what he considered 'the irresponsibilities' of the political life. In Attlee's words, 'he was a majorities man and was impatient with minorities, in which respect he ran counter to one of the most important traditions in the Labour Party. There was no place for rebels in his idea of organisation.' Critics to him were mischievous and malevolent and quite unwilling to find out what he was really trying to do.

Although he had early reached the view, as had Attlee also, that the best, indeed perhaps the only, hope for European security lay in American assistance, he still, in fact, refused to abandon hope of Soviet co-operation. He was anxious to bargain – but to bargain from a position of strength, not weakness. Attacks by members of his own party suggesting that he had 'sold-out' to the Americans infuriated him. He did his best to come to terms with the Soviet. In Moscow at a personal meeting with Stalin he offered to extend the war-time Anglo-Russian Treaty into a fifty-year alliance, and when Stalin replied, 'I should need to amend it', responded, 'Let me know what would suit you.' This he meant sincerely – trying over many weary months without success to get from Stalin exactly what amendments he wanted. 'Our interests are bound to meet in some places,' he said. 'The thing for you and me to do is to keep the ball bearings greased so that there won't be friction when we do meet. I'm ready to do that.' Nor did he think Stalin wanted war. What he feared, as he said in reply to a question from Field-Marshal Smuts at a meeting of Commonwealth Prime Ministers, was that 'the Soviet Policy of expansion has engendered its own dynamic which may prove too strong for him in spite of all his shrewdness and power. I don't think he's planning for war, but he may be unable to control the forces he's started. We've always got to be prepared for that.' It seemed to him that the critics who were always so ready to 'stab him in the back' were wilfully blind.

Attlee, trained in the Parliamentary tradition, was more

tolerant of the left wing, although no less convinced that they did not understand what Britain was up against.

Attlee: There is always a tendency on the part of some people in the Labour Party to over-simplify foreign affairs. It's partly due to a certain woolly idealism; seeing everything black and white when in fact there are all sorts of shades of grey. They mean well but they don't like looking at unpleasant facts. Some of them thought we ought to concentrate all our efforts on building up a Third Force in Europe. Very nice, no doubt. But there wasn't either a material or a spiritual basis for it at that time. What remained of Europe wasn't strong enough to stand up to Russia by itself. You had to have a world force because you were up against a world force.

Williams: And you don't think you sacrificed too much independence to get America in?

Attlee: Of course not. Without the stopping power of the Americans the Russians might easily have tried sweeping right forward. I don't know whether they would, but it wasn't a possibility you could just ignore. It's no good thinking that moral sentiments have any sway with the Russians, there's a good deal of old-fashioned imperialism in their make-up, you know. Their foreign policy has been carried on in much the same way from the days of Queen Catherine the Great. Some of our friends wouldn't see that.

It was the same later on over the American air bases. We had to face this possible danger of the Russians sweeping right across Europe and we had to have something to hold them. One way was air power, where the West was superior to the Russians because of the atom bomb. But the American planes had to be based somewhere – they couldn't fly from across the Atlantic. So we based them here. Obviously it added a certain amount of danger to our own position, but we couldn't have asked other countries, Continental countries, to put themselves in a dangerous position while keeping ourselves out. It was a case where one had to take unpleasant decisions – realistic decisions.

Williams: What would you put as the turning point as far as American policy was concerned?

Attlee: The Berlin air-lift. I think that was the decisive thing. Of course they'd begun to realise earlier that they couldn't just stand out – when we'd had to make it plain to them that we couldn't go on holding the front in Greece, which rather upset them at first. We had to stay in Greece after the war because, if we hadn't, the Communists would have taken over everything and there wouldn't have been any hope of a peaceful Government. But as soon as that danger was out of the way it was high time for us to get out. We were holding the line in far too many places and the Americans in far too few. Germany we had to hold, of course. There was no suggestion, to my mind, that we could afford to withdraw troops from Germany. But Greece was a different matter.

By giving America notice at the right moment that we couldn't afford to stay and intended to pull out we made the Americans face up to the facts in the eastern Mediterranean. As a result we got the Truman Doctrine, a big step. But the Administration was ahead of the people, Harry Truman learnt fast. And although Greece and the Soviet *coup* in Czechoslavakia opened the eyes of Congress quite a lot, it wasn't, I think, until the Berlin air-lift that American public opinion really wakened up to the facts of life. Their own troops were involved in that, you see. Before that there'd been a lot of wishful thinking. In spite of everything I don't think they really appreciated Communist tactics until Berlin.

Williams: Why?

Attlee: Inexperience. I don't think little Jimmy Byrnes had a very clear understanding when he was Secretary of State. Took rather a lawyer's view of things. Marshall had a much bigger grasp, as he showed in the Marshall Plan, and that helped in educating the public.

Williams: Did you have any prior warning of the Marshall Plan?

Attlee: No, I knew nothing of it until he made his speech at

Harvard. Ernie Bevin came round to see me as soon as we got the first reports and we talked it over. We both saw what it could lead to. Ernie took it up very quickly. Without him, in fact, it mightn't have come to anything. It was in very general terms and there were quite a lot of the Americans who didn't want to go anything like so far. They'd have been glad to see it die. But Ernie got on to the French and the others right away and gave it life, and that encouraged America to go ahead.

Even the iron curtain countries wanted to come in at first. The Russians missed a big chance there, they should have agreed and come in themselves. We hoped they would. The satellites were keen and even Molotov's first response wasn't too bad. But Stalin stamped on it. I suppose he thought: 'This is a danger to our ideology. Everyone must depend on us. We are the only people.' A great pity.

Williams: When the stand was made over Berlin did you think there was a real danger that it might bring a response from Russia that would lead to war?

Attlee: It was quite a danger. But it was a risk that had to be taken. I don't, as a matter of fact, believe that Russia was in a position to attack at that time, although one couldn't be sure. They hadn't really begun to rebuild their economy and I didn't think they were ready for a showdown. However, one couldn't depend on it.

I flew out to Berlin when it was on. First time I'd been there since Potsdam. It was mid-winter, bitterly cold, heavy snow on the ground. My plane was interpolated between streams of arriving planes. I saw something of the Berliners. They had a very good Burgomaster – Herr Reuther, a very stout fellow. The spirit of the Berliners was admirable. We saw them at the unloading points, working mighty hard. I think it was a real turning point for them. The spirit of our own and the American troops and air people was very good. They counted it as a great adventure and worked extremely well together. Our troops were mostly young boys, you know. They were in very good fettle, but it could have been very nasty.

With the lifting of the Berlin blockade by the Russians in April 1949 and the signing in Washington in the same month of the North Atlantic Treaty, towards which, at first in the face of many American doubts, Attlee and Bevin had been working patiently for more than a year, there seemed a hope that international relations would improve. Once again these hopes proved false. On 29 September, as the Foreign Ministers' Conference dragged on and on, Bevin wrote to Attlee from New York to say that although he had urged the State Department to be conciliatory on a number of small issues he found the Americans stiff and adamant even on quite unimportant points. 'The atom bomb and the general feeling regarding Russia all combine to make a settlement appear very difficult.'

As for Russia: 'One detects here,' he wrote, 'the feeling that Russia is reverting to the attitude they adopted before the lifting of the blockade. You will find evidence of this in Berlin and Austria, and they particularly resent the United Nations taking up the question of China.

'I mention this because I feel that mischief is brewing again. What form it will take, I cannot tell. It may be a recrudescence of Communist activities in Malaya, or violence in Hong Kong, or industrial upsets at home. I have no doubt that they are closely watching the nervous tension that has developed in France . . .'

As so often now, he concluded: 'I am longing to be home again and I shall be glad when this and the Canadian visit are over.'